

interpretation, but plainly mentions an army (or armies) that will go out.

Bazin concludes his "Turkicized reconstruction" of the Xiong-nu poem that reads as follows:⁹

"süg tägti idqan
boquyï tutqan

with a new "translation": "envoyez l'armée à l'attaque, capturez le commandant!" He then concludes that the Chinese translation is not bad, but just an approximation. Unfortunately, his own "translation" does not stand the slightest chance in the light of all the phonological, morphological, and philological mistakes and speculations discussed above. An attempt to rewrite Chinese translation on the premise that Xiong-nu language must be Turkic obviously does not pay off, nor can it be used as a solid foundation for analysing the poem. The only credible solution will be to try to find matches which exactly follow the Chinese translation.

One of the four words in the poem, *bok-kok, the barbaric title of Liu Yao, is useless for our purposes: as was mentioned above, titles can tell us little about genetic origin of a language. Another word, *s(l)u(s)-ke "army" does not have any parallels in Yeniseian: PY *kār̥e "war" obviously does not fit. However, this is also a cultural word that is easy to borrow, so it cannot be diagnostic. The two remaining words are much more important, for two reasons: both of them represent basic vocabulary, and, being verbal forms, we can expect morphological elements in them that will give us some clue.

Pulleyblank noted that -ŋ is a frequent verbal ending in Yeniseian languages, especially in Kott (1962: 264), but did not go beyond this. I believe that it was due to the severe limitation of materials that he had at his disposal in early 1960s. Thirty years later, however, the situation is much more favorable. Before going into detailed analysis of each verbal form, some general notes on the Yeniseian verbal system are in order.

Yeniseian verbal system is extremely complex, and best of all we know Ket system. There are two major types of verbs, verbs

⁹ It is unlikely to be an Old Persian loanword contrary to (Starostin 1995: 235), since Old Persian *kāra-* means "army" and not "war."